COSTUME

Costume Design: From Script to Fitting

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

How a costume designer reads a script, researches a period, presents a design and takes it through the fitting to the first dress rehearsal.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- script breakdown
- period research
- the sketch
- fabric
- the fitting

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Break the script down

For each character, list every appearance, what they are doing, what has happened to them since the last appearance, and what the audience must understand about them before they speak. A costume chart - characters down the side, scenes across the top - shows the changes at a glance and exposes the quick changes before they become a crisis.

Count the changes, not the characters. Ten actors with three changes each is thirty costumes and a wardrobe department, not a rack of clothes.

Research the period, then the person

Period research gives you silhouette, fabric and fastening: what a wrapper looked like in 1970 Lagos, what a civil servant wore to the office in 1960, what a university student wore in 1978. Then design the person: a character who has money shows it in the fit and the shoes; a character who has lost money shows it in the same suit, altered.

Use primary sources where you can: photographs, family albums, newspaper advertisements, market fabric. Costume books are a starting point and often stop at the European drawing room.

Swatching and the presentation

A design is a drawing plus a fabric. Present the sketch with the swatch attached, and say what the costume is made of, who makes it, and how long it takes. A beautiful drawing in the wrong cloth is a design that will fail in the fitting.

Design in the palette the lighting can carry. Deep blues and blacks disappear against a dark set; a strong colour on the principal actor is a lighting decision as much as a costume one.

The fitting

Fit with the undergarments and shoes the actor will wear, and with the actor's hair as it will be. Pin, mark, and photograph the fitting. Ask the actor to sit, kneel, raise both arms and walk across the room: a costume that cannot do what the part does is not finished.

Book two fittings per costume: one to cut and one to correct. The second fitting is where a costume becomes wearable, and it is the one that is usually cancelled when the schedule slips.

The costume budget

Costume budgets are spent in four places: hire, purchase, making and alteration. For a period play, hire is usually cheapest for the principals and most expensive for the crowd; for a contemporary play, purchase from the market and alter is almost always cheapest.

Cost a costume from the fabric up: metres, lining, thread, buttons, zip, trim, and the tailor's fee, then add twenty per cent. A design presentation without a cost is a wish; a director cannot choose between two designs until both have a number.

Decide early what the department owns and will reuse: suits, shoes, wrappers, school uniforms, choir robes. A costume store with ten good suits and a rail of neutral shirts will dress half the plays a department produces. Keep

it clean, labelled and inventoried, and it will save more money than any single purchase.

Colour under light

Choose costume colours against the set and the lighting plan, not on a white page. A red dress under warm light reads orange; a dark green suit against a dark green wall disappears; a white shirt under a strong front light blooms and takes the face with it.

Test the swatches under the actual lamps before the fabric is bought, and photograph them on a person, not flat. The costume is seen in movement, in light, from a distance, and that is the only test that counts.

Exercises

1. Make a costume chart for a three-act play with six characters and mark every quick change.
2. Research one Nigerian decade and assemble five source photographs with captions.
3. Present one costume design with a sketch, a swatch and a cost estimate, and defend the fabric choice.

Where to read more

Rosemary Ingham and Liz Covey, The Costume Designer's Handbook (1992)

Mary Fernald and Eileen Shenton, Costume Design and Making (1965)

James Laver, Costume and Fashion: A Concise History (1969)

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